

See also: The US Constitution and Bill of Rights 110–117 ■ The United Nations and International Court of Justice 212–219
 ■ The European Convention on Human Rights 230–233 ■ The International Covenant on Civil and Political Rights 256–257

in the creation of human rights treaties, including the International Covenant on Civil and Political Rights (ICCPR) and the International Covenant on Economic, Social, and Cultural Rights (ICESCR), both signed in 1966. The UDHR also influenced many international and regional organizations and has been cited in countless political campaigns around the world.

Origins of the UDHR

In 1941, in the midst of World War II, US president Franklin D. Roosevelt's "Four Freedoms" speech set out the idea that every human being was entitled to freedom of speech and religion, as well as freedom from fear and want. The idea that the postwar world should be founded on the promotion of human rights was contained in the 1942 Declaration by United

World War II created millions of refugees like these Jewish survivors of Nazi persecution in 1945. Globally, there were almost 71 million refugees in 2019, the highest number ever.

Nations, which was drafted by Roosevelt and UK prime minister Winston Churchill. In 1944, at the Dumbarton Oaks conference in Washington, DC—which set out the framework for the creation of the United Nations (UN)—human rights were mentioned without any real definition of what these would mean. But when the Charter of the United Nations was signed in 1945, it contained several specific references to human rights. For example, Article 1 of the Charter said that one of the UN's key functions was "promoting and encouraging respect for human rights and for fundamental freedoms for all without distinction as to race, sex, language, or religion."

The UN's Economic and Social Council set up the Commission on Human Rights in 1946. Its first meeting, in February 1947, was attended by representatives of 15 nations and was tasked with producing a bill of rights. The drafting committee of nine was drawn from those nations and reflected a diverse range »



Eleanor Roosevelt

Born in New York City in 1884, Anna Eleanor Roosevelt was the first lady of the US for the four terms that her husband Franklin Delano Roosevelt (FDR) was in office as US president, from 1933 to 1945. She lobbied for human rights around the world during the 1940s and 1950s and campaigned against poverty and racism in the US, as well as chairing the committee that drafted the UDHR.

The niece of President Theodore ("Teddy") Roosevelt, Eleanor married her fifth cousin Franklin in 1905 and persuaded him to stay in politics after he was disabled by polio in 1921. She often gave campaign speeches and traveled around the US on his behalf. Eleanor remained active in politics after her husband's death in 1945. She died in 1962 and was posthumously among the first group of winners of the UN human rights prize 6 years later for her work on human rights and women's rights.

